MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 3 — Unit 2: Of Parents and Children and Of Marriage and Single Life - Francis Bacon

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

Bacon examines how family relationships shape people’s feelings, choices, responsibilities, and public lives.

Start with a picture

Imagine balancing two baskets. One holds personal freedom and ambition. The other holds care and responsibility for other people. Bacon asks how parents, children, marriage, and single life change that balance.

1. Of Parents and Children

Why are parental feelings complicated?

Parents experience joy, fear, grief, and hope through their children. They may not openly express all those feelings. Children connect parents to the future, but they also bring uncertainty and responsibility.

Why is favouritism harmful?

Treating one child as more worthy than another can create resentment. Differences in affection, money, or expectations can shape how siblings see themselves and each other.

Everyday example: if one child is always praised and another is always compared unfavourably, both may learn to compete for approval rather than support one another.

Why does guidance matter?

Bacon considers how parents should prepare children for adult life. He favours thoughtful education and direction rather than careless indulgence. His advice about choosing a child’s path should be read in its historical context, where parental authority was strong.

A useful modern question is: how can guidance recognise a child’s abilities without erasing the child’s voice?

What does the essay reveal about legacy?

People may hope to continue themselves through children. Bacon also considers other ways a person's work and achievements can outlast a lifetime. His essay connects private affection with the desire to leave something behind.

2. Of Marriage and Single Life

Why might family responsibilities limit public action?

A married person may think first about the welfare and future of a household. Bacon suggests this can make risk-taking or generous public action harder.

But he does not give a simple rule that all married people are selfish and all single people are generous. He also observes that some unmarried people protect only their own wealth or freedom.

What can single life offer?

It may allow greater independence, fewer household obligations, and more time or resources for friends and public service. Yet independence can also become avoidance of commitment.

What can marriage offer?

Family relationships can encourage tenderness, discipline, care, and responsibility. Bacon also makes claims about which professions might suit married or unmarried people. These are his historically situated judgements, not universal facts.

What assumptions should we question?

The essay mostly treats marriage from a man's point of view and often measures a wife by the support she gives her husband. Its expectations about obedience and gender reflect a patriarchal society.

Patriarchal means organised around male authority. In a critical answer, explain that assumption instead of repeating it as a rule for present-day relationships.

Connect the two essays

Both essays ask how relationships influence behaviour. Care can deepen responsibility, but it can also bring partiality, anxiety, or restrictions. Bacon weighs advantages against disadvantages rather than writing a romantic celebration of family life.

His approach is often called **pragmatic**: concerned with how things work in practical life.

Build an exam answer

Use four steps: identify the relationship → explain Bacon's claim → give an example from his reasoning → evaluate its historical assumptions. For marriage, discuss both freedom and responsibility before addressing gender.

Quick check

1. Why is favouritism a problem? **It can damage children’s confidence and sibling relationships.**
2. Does Bacon praise every unmarried person? **No; he also recognises selfish motives.**
3. Should his claims about wives be treated as timeless facts? **No; they require historical and critical examination.**

Memory line

Family brings affection, responsibility, conflict, and questions about the future.

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

Discuss Bacon’s treatment of family relationships and evaluate its assumptions.

Expanded discussion

In Of Parents and Children, family affection appears as a mixture of pleasure, anxiety, hope, and responsibility. Children connect parents with the future, but that connection also exposes parents to uncertainty and grief. Bacon’s discussion of favouritism shows his interest in the consequences of behaviour within a household. Unequal affection and opportunity can shape character and produce rivalry rather than loyalty.

The essay also considers education and guidance. Parents influence children’s prospects through the choices and habits they encourage. Yet Bacon’s view belongs to a world in which parental authority was strongly assumed. A modern reading can recognise the importance of preparation while asking how a child’s abilities and wishes should participate in decisions. Such evaluation makes the historical perspective visible without ignoring the argument itself.

Of Marriage and Single Life weighs independence against obligation. Bacon suggests that household responsibilities can limit public generosity or ambitious action, but he also recognises selfish reasons for remaining unmarried. Marriage may encourage tenderness and discipline, while single life can provide freedom. His method is therefore comparative and pragmatic, although many individual judgements are broad generalisations.

The gender perspective requires particular attention. Wives are often considered through their usefulness to men, and obedience is treated as a desirable quality. These assumptions reflect patriarchal arrangements rather than universal truths about relationships. A strong critical answer can consequently do two things at once: explain Bacon’s analysis of practical consequences and examine the unequal social framework within which he makes that analysis.

Suggested answer structure

1. Parents: mixed emotions and legacy
2. Favouritism and education
3. Marriage: obligations and benefits

4. Single life: independence and selfishness
5. Evaluate patriarchal assumptions

Common mistakes to avoid

Do not present Bacon’s generalisations as psychological facts about every parent or spouse. Avoid treating his historical advice as a rule the reader must follow.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.

Coverage review: extra exam details

Details behind the general advice

In Of Parents and Children, the wish for continuity can extend beyond descendants into lasting works and public achievements. Bacon criticises the damage caused by partial treatment among children and discusses the connection between maintenance, habits, and education. His proposal that parents should choose a child’s course early needs to be explained with its qualification about the child’s aptitude and with recognition of its assumptions about authority.

In Of Marriage and Single Life, claims about clergy, soldiers, magistrates, masters, and subjects show that Bacon tests relationships through public roles as well as private happiness. His account can appear inconsistent: family obligations may limit one kind of generosity but encourage tenderness and steadiness. Discuss this as a tension within practical reasoning, rather than reducing the essay to either “marriage is good” or “marriage is bad.”

Biography and moral evaluation

The unit asks whether Bacon practised his own advice. Separate the essay’s argument from biographical judgement. Bacon’s political career and his 1621 corruption proceedings may be relevant background, but an unsupported story about his marriage cannot explain every sentence. Do not infer a psychological motive from the fact that an essay takes a pragmatic view. A sound evaluation first establishes what the essay argues and then uses reliable evidence for any claim about the author’s conduct.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts, included as a revision checklist, not as predictions of the exam. Longer answers still need evidence from the assigned texts.

1. What are the grievences and joys of parents?
2. Who should decide the profession of children? Why?
3. What are the advantages of not having children?
4. Describe Bacon’s writing style in the essay “Of Parents and Children.”

5. Describe Bacon as a moralist.
6. Did Bacon practise what he preached in his life? Elucidate.
7. What qualities of the Renaissance are found in Bacon?
8. Describe Bacon as an essayist.